# Management Team

Diagnosis, meeting plan, and what to measure

**Prepared by** Shelbi Fox | **Date** 18 August 2026 | **Subject** Anthony, Giovanna and Tatiana

**Short version: your goal is right and your timing is right, but I would change what you say in the room.**

I think this is a structure problem wearing a people problem's clothing. That is good news, because structure is much easier to fix than character.

## The diagnosis I would offer

Read the incident again. You asked for the make-up air to be checked first and it was not. $4,500 got spent by someone who may not have known whether that was theirs to approve. Confusion developed over who owned it. And we nearly paid a second vendor without making the first one finish the job it was called for.

None of that is a shortage of autonomy. It is the absence of an agreed answer to three questions: **who decides, who spends, and who owns a problem that belongs to neither of them.**

Here is what I think actually happened. That was a facilities problem, and facilities probably has no named owner. It sat between Anthony and Giovanna, so each of them reasonably assumed the other had it. That is not a failure of teamwork. It is what happens to any problem with no name on it.

Framing it that way matters, because it means nobody has to be told they behaved badly. You are fixing a gap, not correcting two people.

## Where I would push back

You asked whether this could backfire. Honestly, yes, and I think I can name the mechanism.

**If you step back before the structure exists, you do not create autonomy. You create a vacuum.** And from your own description of them, I would expect Anthony to get more territorial under that pressure, and Giovanna to fill the space by taking over. You would intensify the exact dynamic you are trying to dissolve.

There is also something worth noticing about yesterday. What resolved it was you, with a forceful message and a hard deadline. That tells us they perform well under clear direction. It does not yet tell us they can generate that clarity themselves. I would be careful about reading it as readiness for independence.

One more thing, about Anthony specifically. People defend territory hardest when their ownership feels uncertain. The instinct is to ask him to share more. I would do the opposite and make what is his completely unambiguous. I suspect the guarding eases by itself once he is no longer defending a line nobody has drawn.

And a note on pressure. You want them to challenge each other and even clash when necessary. That only happens where people feel safe being wrong in front of each other. The 36 hour ultimatum worked once. Used repeatedly it would push Anthony further into defensiveness, not out of it.

## On the phrase "killing the father"

I would drop the metaphor. Not because the goal is wrong, but because it keeps you at the centre of a message that is supposed to be about them. It also tells them what to stop doing without telling them what to start doing. And coming a few days after an expensive mistake, "stop bringing me problems" can easily land as "you disappointed me and I am stepping away."

> Same message, pointed forward: **I am giving you authority, not withdrawing support.** That is what you actually mean, and it is much easier to act on.

## The meeting: about 45 minutes

| | Step | Why |
|---|---|---|
| 5 min | **Recognition, on its own, with nothing attached.** Name exactly what they did well: shared information, discussed alternatives, worked the problem together instead of separately. Then stop. | If you attach the new challenge to it, they will remember the challenge and forget the praise. |
| 2 min | **Take a share of it yourself.** "Part of why this went wrong is that I never made clear who owned facilities or who could authorise that spend. That is on me, and we are fixing it today." | The highest leverage two minutes in the meeting. An owner taking part of the blame is the fastest way to make it safe for them to be honest with each other. |
| 5 min | **Tatiana.** Speak to her privately first if you have not already. Then introduce her expanded role as the team growing into what the business needs. | If it arrives in the same breath as the Anthony and Giovanna feedback, it reads as a reaction to their mistake, and you manufacture the rivalry you are trying to avoid. |
| 20 min | **The ownership map.** One name against every area. Not shared, not "both." | This is the real work, and it fixes the actual cause. |
| 10 min | **Spending authority, with real numbers.** | The $4,500 happened because nobody knew which bucket it belonged in. |
| 3 min | **The cross-area rule.** Any problem that is not clearly one person's gets a single named owner within 24 hours, chosen by the three of them, who owns it through to resolution. | Built for your two personalities. It gives Giovanna a legitimate way to support without taking over, and Anthony a way to own without hoarding. |

### The ownership map

Put these on a whiteboard and assign one owner to each. They can consult anyone they like, but one name carries it.

Kitchen and BOH · Front of house · Purchasing and vendors · Scheduling and labour · **Facilities and maintenance** · Cash and banking · Hiring · Training · Guest complaints · Health and safety

Then do the important part. **Find the ones nobody claims.** Those are where your next $4,500 is going to come from. Facilities is almost certainly one of them.

### Spending authority

| Bucket | Rule |
|---|---|
| Decide and act | Under $X. No notification needed. |

| Bucket | Rule |
|---|---|
| Decide and tell me after | $X to $Y. |
| Bring to me first | Over $Y, plus anything touching lease, brand or legal. |

Pick the actual figures in the room. My instinct is to set X higher than feels comfortable. Authority that is too small does not produce autonomy, it produces permission seeking.

## What to measure

You want them accountable for results. These are the numbers that will tell you whether it is working.

| Measure | Target | Why it matters |
|---|---|---|
| **Escalation rate.** Every time something reaches you, tag it: did this genuinely need an owner level decision, yes or no? Count weekly. | Share of "no" falling over 4 weeks | This is the real measure of what you were calling killing the father. It turns the idea into a number you can watch. Baseline it this week. |
| **Unowned problems.** Time from a problem being identified to an owner being named. | Under 24 hours | Directly targets what caused the air handling failure. |
| **Spending outside authority.** | Zero | Any breach means the thresholds are wrong, not that someone misbehaved. |
| **Vendor accountability.** No second vendor engaged on the same issue until the first has been asked in writing to remedy it. | Binary | Stops the specific mistake we nearly made twice. |
| **Weekly management meeting without you.** Thirty minutes, the three of them, producing a short written list of decisions made and items escalated with the reason. | Every week | That list is your escalation data. It also forces them to practise deciding together. |

**What I would expect over the next month:** escalations rising slightly in week one as they test the boundaries, then falling. If they are still rising in week three, your thresholds are too low and they are asking permission rather than using authority.

## One last thing: the $4,500

I would resolve it before moving on. Not as blame, but as "here is the rule that stops this happening again." If spending against your explicit instruction passes with no comment at all, the quiet lesson is that your instructions are optional, and that undermines the accountability you are trying to build. Naming it and fixing it with a threshold does the opposite. It also gives you a natural, non-personal reason to introduce the whole map.

Good luck today. Let me know how it lands. I am genuinely curious which of those ten areas turns out to have no name on it.

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